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JOURNAL TITLE: Information, communication & society

USER JOURNAL TITLE: Information, Communication & Society

ARTICLE TITLE: From activism to polarization: temporal dynamics of #MeToo politicization on Twitter/X

ARTICLE AUTHOR:

VOLUME:

ISSUE:

MONTH:

YEAR: 2025

PAGES:

ISSN: 1468-4462

OCLC #:

Processed by RapidX: 11/7/2025 4:20:33 PM

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Routledge
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Information, Communication & Society

ISSN: 1369-118X (Print) 1468-4462 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rics20

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To cite this article: Jiyoun Suk, Yini Zhang, Rui Wang, Dongdong Yang, Sara Holland Levin, Junwan Seo & Xinxia Dong (02 Nov 2025): From activism to polarization: temporal dynamics of #MeToo politicization on Twitter/X, Information, Communication & Society, DOI: 10.1080/1369118X.2025.2581014

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2025.2581014

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INFORMATION, COMMUNICATION & SOCIETY
https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2025.2581014

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From activism to polarization: temporal dynamics of #MeToo politicization on Twitter/X

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ABSTRACT
This study is focused on how social media activism is politicized over time, attending to diverse groups of users and their response to real-world events on social media. Extending the scholarship on politicization, we hypothesize three temporal dimensions of this process: partisan voices (1) crowd out activist voices, (2) show sustained participation, and (3) respond to events selectively through partisan references and criticisms. Situating our question in the #MeToo movement, we analyzed 83 million #MeToo-related posts on Twitter/X and comprehensive event data between 2017–2020. We conducted user cluster analysis to identify key user groups and supervised machine learning to detect different discourse categories, followed by formal time-series analysis. Results show episodic, asymmetric, and elite-cued politicization of #MeToo. Partisan voices were more dominant at the initial stage of the movement than during the entire timeframe, but they were always more persistent than activist voices. Also, liberals' references to conservatives were spurred by conservative culprits, while conservatives' partisan references spiked when the culprit was either liberal or conservative. Lastly, partisan participation in the discourse was more elite driven than activist participation. We discuss the theoretical and methodological implications for studying the evolution of social media activism in a polarized era.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 18 December 2024
Accepted 21 October 2025

KEYWORDS
Social movement; politicization; social media; digital activism; computational analysis; time-series modeling

Politicization constrains public discussion, undermines social consensus and trust (Bolsen & Druckman, 2015), and intensifies polarization (Simon et al., 2019). Politicization has so far been defined in multiple ways: as a tool to obfuscate and redefine an issue or general consensus (Bolsen & Druckman, 2015), a tendency to highlight political actors in public discourse (Chinn et al., 2020; Hart et al., 2020), and a linguistic discrepancy

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Supplemental data for this article can be accessed online at https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2025.2581014.
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between political and non-political actors or content (Knüpfer et al., 2022; Zhou et al., 2023). In the U.S., politicization has been observed across a range of issues, from science (Druckman, 2022), public health crises like COVID-19 (Hart et al., 2020; Zhou et al., 2023), climate change (Chinn et al., 2020) to personal choices like diets (Chuck et al., 2016). The rise of identity politics and increasing social sorting (Mason, 2018) have further intertwined social-identity-based issues – such as gender justice and LGBTQ + rights – with partisan agendas, making them fertile ground for politicization.

Along this line, this study examines politicization in the context of the #MeToo movement, a prominent case of anti-sexual violence social media activism. Originating in 2006 when activist Tarana Burke coined 'Me Too' to highlight sexual violence against Black girls, and gaining global traction in October 2017 when actress Alyssa Milano encouraged survivors to share their stories online, #MeToo evolved into transnational digital activism (Suk et al., 2024) and remains an influential tool for survivors seeking justice (Gilmore, 2023). The movement's sustained momentum and adaptation to shifting sociopolitical contexts make it an ideal case for studying how politicization unfolds in digital spaces.

Building on prior research, we conceptualize politicization as a temporal and discursive process characterized by two interrelated aspects identified in the literature: (1) actor participation and expansion, the extent to which partisan actors dominate or expand their presence in an issue's public discourse, and (2) discursive conflict, the degree of oppositional engagement, such as inter-party critique (Neumann et al., 2024; Van der Brug & Berkhout, 2024). To examine these aspects in #MeToo, we identify two key sets of actors: activists, who promote anti-sexual violence advocacy without overt party preference or allegiance, and partisans, whom we refer to as individuals or groups (whether elite or ordinary) showing strong, explicit alignment with political parties. Both are political, but they differ in purpose and discursive style. Politicization, in our framework, occurs when partisan actors shift the discursive center of an issue toward partisan agendas. In that sense, activism is political, but not necessarily partisan.

We focus on temporality, which is critical for studying activism initiated by counterpublics, traditionally marginalized groups (Fraser, 1990), who build their visibility through 'processes of contentious publicness' (Kavada & Poell, 2021, p. 193). While some studies track politicization longitudinally by measuring linguistic markers (Chinn et al., 2024; Zhou et al., 2023) or identifying political actors on social media (Chinn et al., 2020), they often overlook the differentiated roles of user groups and how real-world events are woven into politicization efforts in digital spaces. We address this gap by hypothesizing three temporal trajectories of politicization: partisan voices (1) crowd out activist voices, (2) dominate conversations through sustained participation, and (3) respond selectively to events through partisan references and criticisms. The first two reflect actor participation and expansion, while the third captures discursive conflict through inter-party critique. We additionally consider the structural drivers and patterns of politicization, including the role of political elites and asymmetry between the left and right. We analyze 83 million #MeToo-related posts on Twitter alongside event data on sexual harassment and assault accusations (2017–2020). Using network clustering, supervised machine learning, and time-series modeling, we trace how activist and partisan voices shaped, sustained, and contested #MeToo discourse over time.

Literature review

Networked counterpublics: empowerment and politicization

Challenging Habermas' (1991) public sphere, counterpublic theorists have focused on how 'diverse' or 'alternative' publics can challenge dominant norms and hegemonic powers (Fraser, 1990; Squires, 2002). For counterpublics and other activists alike, social media has been recognized as a revolutionary technology, lowering barriers to participation, inviting personalized expressions, and turning communication into a form of organization (Bennett & Segerberg, 2013). They establish their own communities, legitimize their experiences, and build a network of connective action (Jackson et al., 2020; Suk et al., 2021), by 'engag[ing] in debate with wider publics to test ideas and perhaps utiliz[ing] traditional social movement tactics' (Squires, 2002, p. 448). Such efforts are inherently shaped by evolving technological affordances of social media, such as hashtags (Jackson et al., 2020).

However, what fuels counterpublics' activism might also stymie it. While social media facilitates rapid diffusion of movement information and affect (Jost et al., 2018), movements may falter due to limited organizational infrastructure (Tufekci, 2017) or when met with resistance from the existing dominant political, economic, racial, and gender hierarchies (Jackson & Kreiss, 2023). Research shows that as personal narratives and collective demands gain visibility, movements also encounter increasing discursive contention, potentially undermining movement momentum (Suk et al., 2023). One key form of this contention is politicization, driven by party loyalists, when they dominate the discourse and engage in inter-party critique and conflict. That is, when counterpublics challenge existing social structures, privilege, and oppression (Jackson & Kreiss, 2023), political actors seize the opportunity to promote their party stances and agendas, by co-opting and politicizing activism efforts (Knüpfer et al., 2022).

Politicization of activism: conceptual framework

Scholarship on politicization emphasizes different aspects of this concept, often resulting in inconsistent definitions. Nonetheless, politicization is generally understood as a multidimensional phenomenon, of which we see two primary aspects. First, *actor participation and expansion* refers to the extent to which political actors or organizations are visible in public discourse (Hutter, Grande, & Kriesi, 2016; Hutter & Kriesi, 2019). Studies quantify actor mentions (Chinn et al., 2020; Hart et al., 2020) or use network analysis to map alliances or identify clusters of political involvement (Alinejad & Honari, 2024). For example, Hart et al. (2020), drawing on Chinn et al. (2020), define politicization as 'increasing references to political actors' (p. 118). Second, *discursive conflict* pertains to the degree of oppositional stances or disagreement among actors (Knüpfer et al., 2022, 2023; Neumann et al., 2024). Neumann et al. (2024) argue that mere mention of political figures is insufficient to capture politicization, emphasizing instead the importance of conflictual language. Studies along this line track changes in identity or moralistic markers (Chinn et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025), frames (Zhou et al., 2023), and topical prevalence or shifts (Knüpfer et al., 2023; Locatelli et al., 2024). Similarly, Bolsen and Druckman (2015) note politicization as the strategic rhetorical intervention that undermine consensus on an issue. Inter-party critique, for example, is a signal of politicized

contestation (Van der Brug & Berkhout, 2024). Following prior scholarship, we highlight that politicization entails both action involvement and conflict dimensions, where each in isolation only reflects a partial condition.

Importantly, activism and partisanship, while both political, are not synonymous. Although issue evolution can bring activists and partisans into alignment (Carmines & Stimson, 1989; Schickler et al., 2010), they do not necessarily overlap. Partisans engage with both political and non-political topics, and are more likely to be uncivil (Mamakos & Finkel, 2023) and moralistic (Ahn et al., 2024). In #MeToo, which originated in the entertainment industry, partisans may adopt and express views consistent with the positions of their elites (Holman & Kalmoe, 2024), while not meaningfully engaging in anti-violence advocacy. In contrast, activists pursue public recognition of issues through 'collective online expression [which] can offer a public acknowledgment of trauma that provides a forum for open attention to claims, gestures toward common experiences, and affirms a belief in survivors' (Suk et al., 2021, p. 2). Thus, while both groups are political, they diverge in purpose and discursive style.

Structural conditions for politicization in the U.S.

To understand how politicization unfolds in digital spaces, we must consider the broader structural and communicative environments in which these dynamics are embedded. Politicization emerges from its deep-seated social, political, and media structures. At a societal level in the U.S., rising partisan animosity and 'sorting' have played a significant role in shaping how social causes are perceived through a partisan lens (Mason, 2018). The growing integration of partisanship into a core social identity has resulted in the 'generalized politicization of Americans' otherwise nonpolitical identities' compared to the past (Mason & Wronski, 2018, p. 260). This includes attitudes towards social minority groups – including racial minorities, women, LGBTQ+, and immigrants – more tightly coupled with partisan identity (Engelhardt, 2021; Mason, 2018; Suk et al., 2022), affecting how their advocacy efforts, such as #MeToo, are perceived and contested (Kam & Archer, 2021; Masuoka et al., 2023).

This process is facilitated by partisan elites and media. Political elites provide accessible cues that shape public attitudes (Hansen & Dolan, 2022; Holman & Kalmoe, 2024). Partisan media frame social issues in ways that transform them from broadly shared concerns into markers of ideological division (Su et al., 2024). Politicization operates through motivated reasoning, making people more likely to accept information aligned with their prior beliefs and to dismiss contradictory evidence (Taber & Lodge, 2006). In this way, voices from party loyalists can dominate activist discursive spaces, especially when reinforced by elite rhetoric, party tensions, and frame contestation (Fowler & Gollust, 2015).

These tendencies are amplified on social media. Platforms promote ideological sorting by letting users choose the 'right' side (Törnberg, 2022). Political elites, most engaged and politically active, capitalize on this structure to amplify politically motivated narratives and frames. Platform algorithms that prioritize engagement, along with the homogeneous network of followings (Zhang et al., 2023), further facilitate the dissemination of emotionally or politically charged content, providing partisan messages with structural advantages. In these environments, due to the public's limited attention span (Cinelli et

al., 2021), only the most committed actors are likely to sustain a given movement after sporadic bursts of public attention (Freelon et al., 2018), with a considerable number of conversations deviating from the substance of the campaign.

Temporal framework of politicization

Focusing on the 'publicness' of digital discourse, Kavada and Poell (2021) argue that social media activism and the contestation surrounding it are inherently temporal, moving through time and key moments. On social media, where visibility is a primary political goal and engagement metrics function as a currency within the attention economy, actors compete for prominence within shared networks (Banet-Weiser, 2018). Traditional movement organizations pursue strategic timing through 'analytic activism' (Karpf, 2016); similarly, partisans aim to capture attention and visibility by interacting with counterpublic activism. Their politicization efforts, then, unfold as temporally structured acts.

We thus view politicization as a *process* of partisan act, beyond the *outcome* of partisan act, aligning with Kavada and Poell's (2021) call to study flows of public contestation as processes rather than a static phenomenon. We expand the literature by proposing three interrelated dimensions of politicization: partisan voices (1) crowd out activist voices (*actor participation and expansion*), suggesting the growing salience of political actors in public discourse, (2) dominate conversations through sustained participation (*actor participation and expansion)*, capturing the durability of actor involvement beyond the overall volume of voice, and (3) engage in partisan references and criticisms by selectively responding to real-world events (*conflict*), indicating politicization through discursive contention. We further consider the role of partisan elites and ideological asymmetry, reflecting how deeper structures of ideological contestation contribute to the politicization of issues.

Dimensions of politicization

Crowding out of activist voices. Although counterpublics initiate social media activism and gain visibility early on, their presence is not guaranteed to remain central. In digital attention economies, where diverse actors compete for visibility, party-driven participants are often more motivated to amplify social media presence of their political agenda (Zhang et al., 2023). Partisans, often embedded in echo chambers (Jiang et al., 2021), are driven by strong in-party identities to promote their stance and disparage out-groups (Barberá, 2020; Yu et al., 2024). Their voices, particularly when adversarial toward the out-party, are amplified through social validation from like-minded others, endorsement from elites, and platform algorithms (Ahn et al., 2024; Yu et al., 2024). To some extent, social media has provided 'a new megaphone' for strong partisans, particularly those who tend to be uncivil and outrage-prone on topics both political and non-political (Mamakos & Finkel, 2023).

By contrast, activist voices, though exhibiting spontaneity and rapid diffusion, can fragment, falter, and fail to signal power compared to partisan voices due to the rapidly shifting public attention (Lorenz-Spreen et al., 2019), limited organizational infrastructure (Tufekci, 2017), and possibly their tendency not to employ outrage-sparking and attention-grabbing tactics as partisans do. An absence of echo chambers among activists

further makes it harder to collectivize voices and compete with cohesive partisan networks. In sum, partisan voices might drown out activist voices over time, which, at the aggregate level, is reflected as an upward trend in partisan voices, eclipsing activist voices. We hypothesize that #MeToo is politicized as the share of partisan voices increases over time (**H1**).

Sustained engagement by partisan actors. While partisan dominance in voice share reflects one facet of politicization, it does not fully capture the *durability* of engagement. Online collective attention typically unfolds in short bursts, with users shifting rapidly from one topic to another, which is a pattern shaped by both network structures and cognitive biases toward central or influential accounts (De Domenico & Altmann, 2020). Emotional responses (Suk et al., 2021) and personalized expressions (Bennett & Segerberg, 2013) – common among activists – are often contagious but fleeting (Zhang et al., 2019).

However, persistent attention and sustained engagement are critical for the visibility and impact of movements. 'Repeat participation' serves as a strong signal of commitment (Freelon et al., 2018, p. 995). Evidence from #BLM and gun debates shows that partisan discourse tends to endure and sustain visibility persistently after initial events (Klein et al., 2022; Zhang et al., 2019). This persistence is often attributed to consolidated partisan networks, where high-profile partisan elites collectively amplify aligned messages within tightly connected groups (Zhang et al., 2023), resulting in multiple waves of message diffusion within those networks. Therefore, we hypothesize that #MeToo is politicized with partisan voices being more sustained than activist voices (**H2**).

Event-driven selective attention and critique. The third dimension concerns how partisans *selectively respond* to real-world events with *partisan references and criticisms* against the opposing party. While shared awareness of real-world events, like media events (Lin et al., 2014), can trigger collective behaviors online, different user groups also seize different events to promote favorable narratives. Partisans, for example, filter their events through identity-protective cognition and motivated reasoning (Taber & Lodge, 2006) to amplify those that affirm in-group narratives or challenge opponents. Research in immigration and gun debates shows that conservatives and liberals selectively emphasized and responded to distinct events to reinforce their positions (Jiang et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2019).

In our context, we expect partisans' selective engagement concentrated on a subset of #MeToo events, such as accusations involving out-party, with inter-party mentions and criticisms. By contrast, activists, while politically engaged, are less likely to respond through partisan references or criticisms, and their responsiveness to events remains unknown. We ask: How do partisan vs. activist voices differ in their mentions and criticisms of liberals vs. conservatives in response to event features in #MeToo (**RQ1**)*?*

Focal mechanisms: elite cueing and ideological asymmetry

The role of political elites. An important structural force behind politicization is the role of political elites. As discussed above, politicization is often a top-down process, where political elites, including politicians, news media, or influencers (Flamino et al., 2023), provide cues and talking points to shape their followers' opinions. Occupying central

positions within digital networks, they possess the ability to propagate expansive information flows (Dubois & Gaffney, 2014). In the context of #MeToo, elite cues and partisan media framing influenced partisans' attitude toward sexual violence and gender justice, turning it into an issue aligned with the Democratic Party and reinforcing party conflict (Ghosh et al., 2022; Holman & Kalmoe, 2024; Su et al., 2024). Elite intervention can thus accelerate the crowding out of activist voices by directing partisan networks to mobilize around activist discourse, enhance persistence by sustaining attention over time, and intensify discursive conflict by encouraging targeted criticisms of political opponents. We ask: to what extent do political elites shape politicization (**RQ2**)?

Ideological asymmetry. The manifestations of politicization likely differ across ideologies lines. Conservatives and liberals in the U.S. operate within distinct structural and psychological contexts that condition their engagement in politics (Grossmann & Hopkins, 2016; Suk et al., 2023). Conservatives tend toward more hierarchical and centralized message structures (Bennett et al., 2018), seek ideological confirmation and cognitive stability (Jost, 2017), and engage in 'hashjacking' to promote political agenda (Bode et al., 2015). Conservative discourse is also often dominated by a smaller number of elites and opinion leaders, increasing message uniformity (Haupt et al., 2021; Zhang et al., 2024b).

These structural and psychological asymmetries likely shape how partisans respond to movements like #MeToo, particularly given the ideological divides on issues of sexual violence and gender. Liberals and conservatives, and their parties, have shown contrasting positions on gender-related political preferences (Gillion et al., 2020) and on sexual assault and harassment (Kam & Archer, 2021; Masuoka et al., 2023). Partisan framing of #MeToo has reflected these divides, with right-wing emphasizing authority-focused and legalistic frames, while left-wing focusing on cultural and survivor-oriented frames (Ghosh et al., 2022; Su et al., 2024). Democratic women tend to punish candidates with sexual violence scandals than Republican men (Masuoka et al., 2023), and individuals are more forgiving of allegations against in-party legislators than out-party legislators (Costa et al., 2020). However, little is known about how this response manifests and evolves on social media asymmetrically across ideologies, especially in competition with activist voices. Therefore, we ask how politicization reveals asymmetry between conservatives and liberals (**RQ3**).

Method

Twitter and event data

Using Twitter API v2 (Academic Track), we collected English #MeToo-related posts from October 2017 to December 2020 (keywords in Supplemental Material A; Zhang et al., 2024a), spanning the hashtag's viral emergence through the 2020 U.S. election. The corpus includes 83,096,334 tweets from 8,088,600 users; a manual review of 500 random tweets found 98.4% relevance.

We also compiled an event list from media sources and timelines (see Supplemental Material B). Two trained coders curated events involving sexual assault or harassment accusations against prominent social and political figure and their follow-up

developments. Coded variables included (percentage agreement = 86–100%; Krippendorf's α = .81–1.00): (a) event date, (b) major actor in the event (victim, culprit, government entity/personnel, or other), (c) whether the case was an initial accusation, (d) whether the alleged culprit was known, (e) culprit's name, (f) accusation date, (g) industry affiliation, and (h) political leaning.

Analytic approaches

Operationalizing politicization

Politicization is a multidimensional process requiring both actor involvement and discursive conflict. We measure three observable dimensions through computational indicators. First, *partisan voices crowding out activist voices* is assessed by the relative share of partisan voices over time, i.e., the volumes of tweets from different user groups detected via cluster analysis. Second, *sustained participation*, the activity durability beyond volume, is measured as temporal persistence using time-series autocorrelations of daily posting activity. Third, *event-driven selective references and criticisms* are captured through supervised machine learning of partisan references and criticisms, combined with time-series modeling of event effects.

User clustering

To measure actor participation (H1 and H2), we applied Vintage Sparse Principal (VSP) component analysis to retweet patterns, which capture agreement or at least an interest or influence (Flamino et al., 2023). VSP, a scalable spectral clustering method, effectively identifies user similarity in multivariate data (Rohe & Zeng, 2020) and has been shown to outperform alternatives such as Louvain (Shuster et al., 2024). In our dataset, 77% of tweets are retweets. Based on the scree plot, we set the number of clusters to 50, balancing efficiency and granularity.

Two authors labeled clusters by observing the most retweeted (determined by the number of retweets) and representative (determined by the cluster loading coefficient) users. We categorized clusters into anti-sexual-violence (SV) activists, conservatives, liberals, attentive publics (reference group), other activists (e.g., justice reform, immigration), miscellaneous, and irrelevant (e.g., non-U.S. or uninterpretable). *Partisans* (conservatives, liberals) are users with explicit support or alignment with political parties, while *activists* promote social causes without associating with political parties. The attentive publics cluster (Wells et al., 2020) consists of users engaging tangentially with viral accounts but without clear partisan or movement identity.[1] Our analysis focuses on these first four groups. For validation, we randomly sampled users, labeled them by referring to account information and top tweets, and compared results with cluster assignments, which showed a satisfactory level of accuracy. We also identified the top 20 most retweeted accounts in each category for RQ2 on elite involvement. See Supplemental Material C and D for user clustering details and plots.

Supervised machine learning

To measure discursive conflict (RQ1), we classified tweets referencing and criticizing liberals vs. conservatives. Three coders annotated 5,000 tweets with two variables (percentage agreement = 96–99%; Krippendorff's α = .83–.87): (1) **partisan mention** (references

to Democrats/liberals or Republicans/conservatives, including political figures, elites, and partisan organizations) and (2) **partisan criticism** (from mild disapproval to moral outrage).

Using annotated tweets, we trained BERT (Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers; Devlin et al., 2019) classifiers. Preprocessing included removing URLs, 'RT"s, extra spaces, and non-ASCII characters. After training and evaluating models, we applied them to unlabeled tweets with decision thresholds set (.8 for mentions and .85/.75 for Democrat/Republican criticism) to ensure high confidence. Performance was satisfactory (F1 = .80–.87; precision = .79–.90; recall = .72–.97; details in Appendices E–F).

Time series modeling

For H1, we computed daily tweet percentages from user categories and tested monotonic trends using the Mann-Kendall test (Avalle et al., 2024). For H2, we measured persistence via autocorrelation functions, assessing correlations between daily counts and lagged values (Zhang et al., 2019). For RQ1, we used Prais-Winsten regression (Park & Mitchell, 1980) to examine how changes in predictors from t-1 to t correlate with outcome changes. We ran models for mentions and criticisms of liberals vs. conservatives across the four cluster categories. For RQ3, we compared the results by ideology.

Results

Trend in tweet percentages across users

H1 posited that the share of partisan voices increased over time. Liberals contributed the largest share of all tweets, accounting for 37.9% of all tweets, followed by attentive publics (30.3%), conservatives (9.3%), and anti-SV activists (5.9%). Figure 1 (left panel) displays the daily percentage of tweets from each cluster category. Over the three-year period, the share of liberal voices displayed an overall downward trend, and the share of conservative voices had two major spikes, one in late 2018 (Justice Brett Kavanaugh's confirmation hearing) and the other during early 2020 (the U.S. presidential primary elections). The share of anti-SV activist voices remained relatively stable with slight fluctuations. In contrast, the share of attentive publics' voices showed a general upward trend. Mann-Kendall tests confirm a statistically significant downward monotonic trend in the share of liberal ($Z_{MK} = -18.2$, $p < .001$) and conservative ($Z_{MK} = -2.4$, $p < .01$) voices, and significant upward monotonic trend in the share of attentive publics' voices ($Z_{MK} = 13.7$, $p < .001$). There was not a monotonic trend in the share of anti-SV activist voices ($Z_{MK} = 0.6$, $p = .52$). Therefore, the pattern over the three-year period does not support H1.

To further understand the nuanced pattern, we examined the initial phase of the movement when #MeToo first received intense public attention and scrutiny (till the end of 2017) (Figure 1 right panel). Mann-Kendall tests show a statistically significant upward monotonic trend in the share of liberal ($Z_{MK} = 2.1$, $p < 0.05$) and conservative ($Z_{MK} = 3.1$, $p < .001$) voices, no significant monotonic trend in the share of anti-SV activist voices ($Z_{MK} = -1.7$, $p = .09$), and a statistically significant downward monotonic trend in the share of attentive publics' voices ($Z_{MK} = -4.7$, $p < .001$) during the initial stage of the movement. Together, these results suggest an increasing trend in partisan

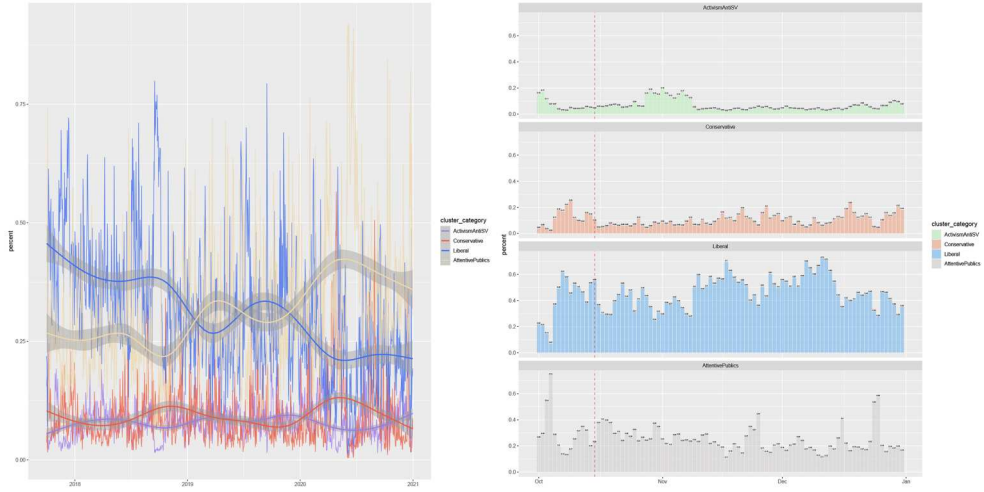

Figure 1. Percentage of tweets by cluster category per day from 2017–2020 (Left) and in 2017 (Right).

voices and a stable pattern in activist voices in the initial phase of the movement; however, during the three-and-a-half-year period, partisan voices, while dominating in terms of relative percentage, trended downwards and activist voices remained stable. The changing share of voices applied to both conservatives and liberals (RQ3).

Persistence in tweets across users

H2 hypothesized that partisan voices were more sustained than activist voices. For the liberal daily tweet time series, day 0's observation was strongly correlated with day 1's ($\varphi 1 = .86$) and day 2's ($\varphi 2 = .76$), and after 33 days did the correlation become not statistically significant at the 95% level (Figure 2). Similarly, for conservatives, $\varphi 1 = .83$, $\varphi 2 = .71$, and φ remained significant until day 36. These high and sustained autocorrelation values among partisan groups suggest a consistent and sustained engagement over time. Autocorrelations for anti-SV activists were lower on average than those for partisan groups, with $\varphi 1 = .71$ and $\varphi 2 = .50$, but there was a 7-day cycle, suggesting a regular cyclical pattern of posting activity. This indicates that despite activists' less day-to-day consistency in comparison with partisans, there were recurrent spikes on a possibly weekly basis among activists, possibly suggesting a planned messaging strategy. On the other hand, autocorrelation plots of the attentive publics were relatively short-lived compared to others, becoming nonsignificant after 21 days. Their low autocorrelations (ranging from .71 to .09) also suggest a more transient pattern. These results provide support for H2: partisan voices were more sustained than activist voices, but the latter was recurrent albeit not strong.

Event features and tweet activity across users

RQ1 examines event-driven partisan mentions and criticisms. Among tweets with partisan mentions (N = 30,899,622), 70.3% referenced both sides (N = 21,729,329), 12.8%

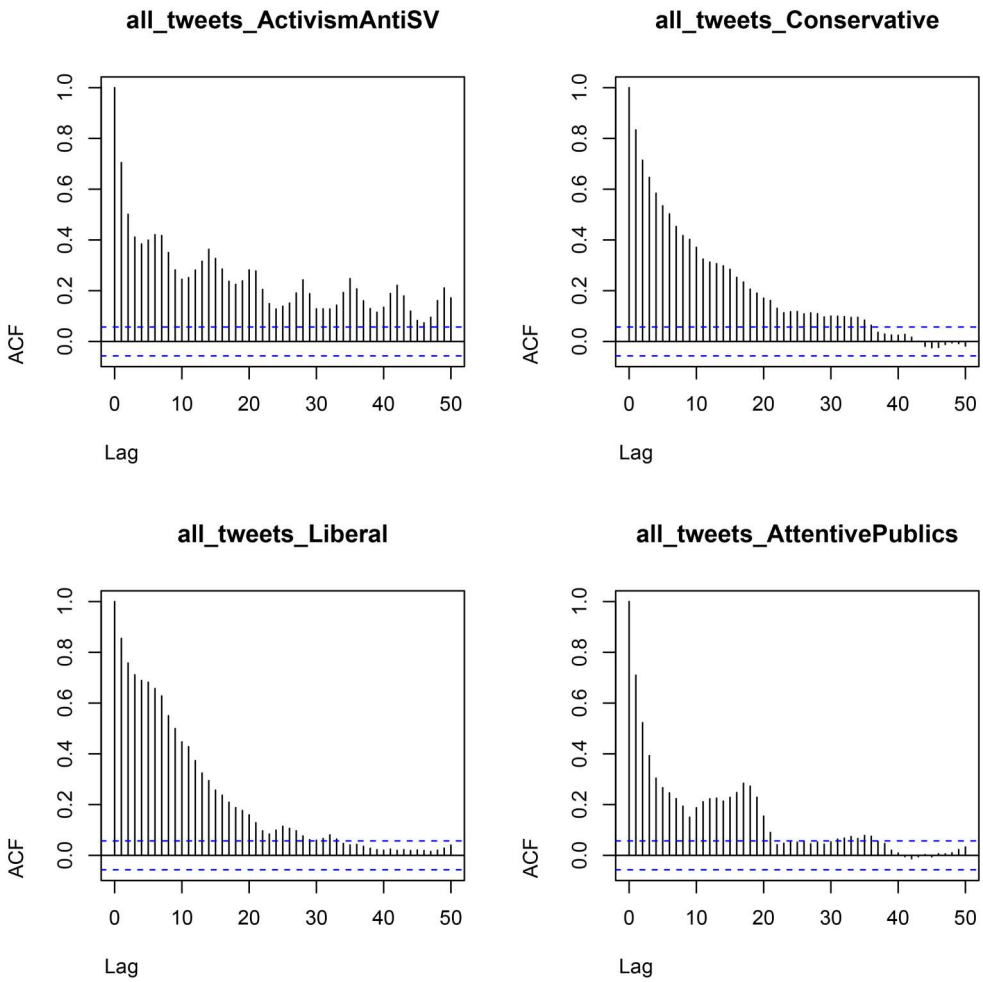

Figure 2. Auto-correlation functions for tweets by cluster category.

mentioned Democrats/liberals only, and 16.8% mentioned Republicans/conservatives only. Among tweets with partisan criticisms (N = 9,157,670), 91.4% targeted Republicans/conservatives, 2.1% Democrats/liberals, and 6.5% both. In the full corpus, Dem-only (Rep-only) mentions comprised 4.8% (6.3%); Dem-only (Rep-only) criticisms 0.2% (10.1%). Overall, partisan references and criticisms were a relatively small share of the #MeToo discourse.

Prais-Winsten regressions (Supplemental Material G for full tables) show that liberals' mentioning of Democrats/liberals only was positively predicted by culprits from the corporate sector ($b = 1676.40$, $p < .05$) but negatively predicted by known culprits ($b = -1748.62$, $p < .01$). Among conservatives, mentions of Democrats/liberals only were positively associated with liberal culprits ($b = 192.66$, $p < .05$) and negatively predicted with initial accusations ($b = -450.91$, $p < .001$). Anti-SV activists showed no event predictors. For attentive publics, mentioning of Democrats/liberals only was positively predicted across culprit industries and negatively by known culprits ($p < .001$ across all).

Mentioning of Republicans/conservatives only increased for both liberals and conservatives when culprits were conservative. Liberals also responded to culprits from news media ($b = 6029.57$, $p < .05$), the judiciary ($b = 14385.46$, $p < .001$), entertainment ($b = 6259.49$, $p < .05$), corporate ($b = 5940.91$, $p < .05$), and academia ($b = 6085.47$, $p < .05$). For anti-SV activists, judiciary ($b = 313.95$, $p < .001$) and corporate culprits ($b = 141.65$, $p < .05$) were positive predictors. For attentive publics, mentions of Republicans/conservatives only were negatively predicted by initial accusations ($b = -333.42$, $p < .05$) but positively predicted by judiciary culprits ($b = 1868.23$, $p < .01$).

For criticisms, liberal criticisms of Democrats/liberals only were negatively associated with initial-accusation events ($b = -46.05$, $p < .01$), and no event features were associated with Democrats/liberals only criticisms from other groups. By contrast, criticisms of Republicans/conservatives only were positively associated – among liberals and attentive publics – with events involving judiciary culprits. Attentive publics' criticisms of Republicans/conservatives were also related to additional event features, whereas no event features were significantly related to criticisms by conservatives or anti – SV activists.

Role of elites

Retweets dominated activity across groups (anti-SV activists 71.6%; conservatives 79.3%; liberals 83.7%; attentive publics 85.9%). And a small share of users generated most retweets: the top decile accounted for 85.7–96.2%, consistent with a power-law distribution (Supplemental Material H). Among liberals and conservatives, the top 20 most-retweeted accounts were mostly political influencers, including @funder (co-founder of the Democratic Coalition), @SethAbramson (political commentator), @kylegriffin1(MSNBC executive producer) on the left and @charliekirk11 (Turning Point USA co-founder), @RealCandaceO (political commentator), @RyanAFournier (Students for Trump co-founder) on the right. About 30% of conservatives' and 20% of liberals' tweets were retweets of their tweets. In contrast, the top 20 accounts among activists and attentive publics were mostly non-political and accounting for only 8% to 9% of tweets. These patterns suggest that politicization by partisans was relatively elite driven (RQ2). Additionally, the same top 20 accounts drove more retweeting among conservatives than among liberals, speaking to a more consolidated retweeting network on the right (RQ3).

Discussion

Our study centers around one prominent challenge against social media activism: partisan politicization, where movement discourse is redirected toward party conflict by partisan actors. While politicization and polarization can, in some cases, clarify ideological distinctions and mobilize engagement (Smith et al., 2024), its manifestation in this context often shifts attention away from substantive activist goals toward performative partisan conflict (Suk et al., 2023). This dynamic risks weakening the sustainability and public resonance of activism, particularly when movements are subsumed into cycles of moral outrage and ideological battles.

In our framework, politicization is a temporal and discursive process that requires both actor participation (expansion and durability of partisan presence) and discursive conflict (event-gated inter-party mentions and criticisms). We hone in on the temporal dimensions of politicization. Examining #MeToo discourse through this lens, we find evidence of episodic politicization through different user group dynamics and relationship with real-world events. First, in the initial phase, partisans dominated the conversation, though anti-SV activists showed a regular albeit weak, presence. When looking at the longer timeframe, partisan voices were gradually eclipsed by those of attentive publics, whereas activist voices retained their regularity and stability. Second, partisan voices remained stickier than activist voices, persisting longer once started. These results paint a picture of passionate and vocal partisans that eclipsed activists, who, though maintained a stable presence, failed to project their voices loud and strong.

Third, we highlight selective engagement with real-world events. Unlike activists, partisans selectively reacted to those accused of sexual violence and holding opposite political ideologies. Specifically, conservatives mentioned liberals when the culprit was liberal, and mentioned conservatives when the culprit was conservative. However, liberals mentioned conservatives only when the culprit was conservative and did not mention liberals when the culprit was liberal. This suggests a relatively selective engagement depending on the party ideology of the culprit, especially among liberals. Conservatives appeared to seize politically opportune moments to amplify discourse about both co-partisans and opponents.

When it comes to criticism from partisans, liberals' criticism of conservatives was significantly predicted by the culprit being from the judiciary. However, conservatives' criticism of liberals was not predicted by any variable in the model. Our descriptive reading of most retweeted tweets indicates that conservatives' criticism of liberals was attuned to specific political moments, such as elections or Supreme Court justice nominee hearings, rather than #MeToo-related accusations. For example, the right-wing political activist Charlie Kirk's tweet (retweeted 3,969 times), condemned Democrats' attack on the Supreme Court Justice nominee Amy Coney Barrett while remaining silent about President Biden's sexual accusations ('It's insane – Democrat Senators are willing to ask Amy Coney Barrett of all people if she's ever sexually assaulted anyone but they ignore mountains of credible evidence of sexual assault by their nominee, Joe Biden'). Conservative commentator Candace Owens's tweet (retweeted 9,310 times), also focused on Democrats opposing Kavanaugh ('Any person who cannot admit that the #metoo movement has fully deteriorated into a political weapon is either a liar or a coward. Any person who actually cares about sexual assault victims should be vehemently & vocally against what the Democrats are staging against Kavanaugh'). These examples suggest that conservative criticism was less influenced by #MeToo-specific events/accusations but more reactive in nature to liberal criticisms of conservatives.

Elite amplification helps explain these temporal patterns. The clustering results and top retweeted accounts show that political elites contributed to the formation partisan groups. Once elites entered the discourse, their tweets likely triggered reinforcing waves of retweeting, giving partisan voices a more durable presence than activist voices. This observation points to a top-down process of politicization of #MeToo, mobilized by elites to pursue political goals or to simply gain engagement.

Yet this process unfolded asymmetrically. Conservative group included a small set of elites producing a disproportionate share of retweets, indicating a tightly coordinated amplification structure on the right (González-Bailón et al., 2022). Conservatives' tendency to reactively respond to liberals' mentions and criticisms reflects a motivation to counter threatening discourse and restore order (Sterling et al., 2020). These dynamics extend prior evidence of ideological asymmetry (Brady et al., 2019) suggesting how concentrated elite influence and reactive engagement reinforced partisan conflict in #MeToo discourse. Such asymmetries complicate efforts to limit politicization: when one side escalates, the other is incentivized to reciprocate. Platform logics that privilege emotionally and ideologically charged content can further intensify this process, helping explain both the persistence of partisan voices and the clustering of conflict at high-salience moments.

It is noteworthy that the reference group, attentive publics, assumed an increasingly prominent presence over time, suggesting the general expansion of #MeToo from activists and partisans to the broader public. Assembled by hybrid-media dynamics rather than over partisan or activist alignment, they were mainly influenced by celebrities that weighed in on #MeToo-related events and by moderate news outlets. Their great attention and engagement over time, in contrast with declining attention from partisans, suggests that for political elites and rank-and-file partisans #MeToo might be plausibly losing its 'novelty' and that they have focused on other issues. We view this as a redistribution of attention pathways, from partisan channels toward broader audience routes. The rise of attentive publics also suggests that hybrid-media diffusion through moderate news and celebrity pathways tempers partisan dominance and makes politicization sporadic rather than cumulative. Practically, it might mean a better opportunity for anti-SV activists to reach a broader public.

Our study contributes to existing literature on politicization by offering a multidimensional, temporal framework that traces how partisan discourse evolves within activist spaces online. Prior studies have documented partisan engagement with movements such as #BlackLivesMatter (e.g., Freelon et al., 2018) but often emphasize elite messaging only or static outcomes. We instead conceptualize politicization as a process shaped by dynamic interactions among actors, discourse, and real-world events and examine the role of elites and political asymmetry as structural mechanisms. This temporal lens extends accounts that focus primarily on mentions of political elites or influencer rhetoric and is especially informative for counterpublics, whose visibility and opposition fluctuate over time. Calls for changes should be understood in a temporal manner to better understand the nature of the movement and its social and political context – not a static occurrence but a process shaped by ongoing interactions between online interactions and offline developments.

Methodologically, we integrate user-level and content-level analyses with temporal modeling to trace heterogeneous activity across groups. Unlike prior work that treats online discourse as a single collective conversation, we map its social and thematic evolution by identifying subgroups and their shifts in focus. This combination yields a more granular framework for understanding how digital discourse evolves and how it is amplified or muted over time.

We note several limitations. First, we recognize the role of platform algorithms as an additional structural factor of politicization. While we noted that politicization is

especially pronounced on social media, examining this is beyond the study's scope. This can also be related to why some elite messages garnered higher retweets, as our descriptive reading reveals, contributing to the formation of partisan groups and politicization. Future studies can more systematically analyze the nature of messaging by elites and explore how algorithmic and elite forces intersect to shape the visibility of certain voices. Second, data collection was confined to English content with a U.S. focus. #MeToo evolved uniquely across geo-linguistic contexts, with its politicization being evident in the U.S (Suk et al., 2024). However, future studies considering cross-cultural perspectives would be valuable. Third, we focused on a single platform, Twitter. While central to political discussions, future studies should include other platforms or multi-platform comparisons. Reddit, for example, is also another platform that facilitate political discussions among like-minded communities (Li et al., 2024). Lastly, our timeframe focused on 2017–2020. Though it covered its foundational phase from initiation to the 2020 election cycle, future research could extend the timeline to examine its evolution in subsequent years, investigating intensified or weakened politicization.

By empirically identifying three temporal dimensions of politicization, our framework shows how politicization of social media activism unfolds over time through the interplay of user behaviors and offline events. This temporal perspective highlights how activist efforts can be weakened or redirected as movements become entangled with partisan dynamics. Our findings indicate that #MeToo experienced asymmetric, episodic, and elite-cued politicization at salient moments. Theoretically, this underscores the need to treat politicization as temporally contingent and user-dependent; practically, it points to activist strategies that leverage broader audience pathways to sustain visibility and resonance.

Note

1. Following Wells et al. (2020), we use 'attentive publics' to denote audience formations that assemble around an issue via hybrid-media dynamics (platform amplification, news coverage, punctuated events) without overt partisan or activist alignment.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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Data availability statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author, upon reasonable request.

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